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PROCESSING LABEL HERE

Write your **student number** in the boxes above. **Letter**

Philosophy

Question and Answer Book

VCE Examination – Tuesday 11 November 2025

- Reading time is **15 minutes**: 11.45 am to 12 noon
- Writing time is **2 hours**: 12 noon to 2.00 pm

Materials supplied

- Question and Answer Book of 24 pages

Instructions

- Use the additional space at the end of this book if you need extra space to complete an answer.

Students are **not** permitted to bring mobile phones and/or any unauthorised electronic devices into the examination room.

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Section A

Instructions

- Answer **all** questions in the spaces provided.
- Write your responses in English.
- Each question in Section A is worth 10 marks, to be assessed holistically and with no specific mark allocation for each question part. Your response will be assessed according to the assessment criteria set out on page 21.

Question 1 (10 marks)

> … You want if possible – and there is no madder 'if possible' – *to abolish suffering*; and we? – it really does seem that *we* would rather increase it and make it worse than it has ever been! Wellbeing as you understand it – that is no goal, that seems to us an *end*! A state which soon renders man ludicrous and contemptible – which makes it *desirable* that he should perish! The discipline of suffering, of *great* suffering – do you not know that it is *this* discipline alone which has created every elevation of mankind hitherto? That tension of the soul in misfortune which cultivates its strength, its terror at the sight of great destruction, its inventiveness and bravery in undergoing, enduring, interpreting, exploiting misfortune, and whatever of depth, mystery, mask, spirit, cunning and greatness has been bestowed upon it – has it not been bestowed through suffering, through the discipline of great suffering?

Source: F Nietzsche, *Beyond Good and Evil*, Penguin Group, London, 2003, p. 155

a. With reference to the passage above, explain how Nietzsche might respond to the view that self-discipline is a key ingredient in the good life.

Do not write in this area.

b. How might **one** other thinker studied in Unit 3 respond to Nietzsche's view on the role of self-discipline in the good life?

c. What is the role of suffering in the good life? Provide your own justified response to this question. Support your reasoning with an example.

Do not write in this area.

Question 2 (10 marks)

Distributive justice, the first type, organizes the allotment of public goods—honor, money, property. It depends on a "geometric" or proportional notion of equality. For instance, two people get an equal amount to eat for dinner when each is served a portion in proportion to his appetite. Although one diner may get a larger serving than another, each will have been treated equally provided that in each case the serving matches the appetite. Every type of regime has its own principle of desert for deciding how to make proportional distributions: aristocracies, for instance, assign greater benefits to nobly born citizens. Aristotle advocates instead an approach in which people receive benefits from the public store equivalent to what they have given to it, and he consistently argues, for instance, that the rich should contribute proportionally more wealth to the public store and receive proportionally more honor in return. Honor is the good that the poor have to give.

Source: DS Allen, *Talking to Strangers: Anxieties of Citizenship Since* Brown v. Board of Education, The University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 2006, pp. 121 and 122

a. Consider the following viewpoint: 'Justice involves distributing society's goods unevenly.'

How would Allen draw on Aristotle's approach described in the passage above, to respond to this viewpoint? Use a contemporary example of your own to support your response.

Do not write in this area.

b. How might **one** other thinker studied in Unit 3 respond to the view that uneven distribution of goods is just?

c. To what extent does the good life with others require that everyone has an equal share? Provide your own justified response to this question.

Do not write in this area.

Question 3 (10 marks)

The following extract is from an interview with Violet CoCo by The Philosophy Club. CoCo is an environmental activist and a member of Extinction Rebellion, a global movement that agitates for government action on climate change. The group organises acts of nonviolent civil disobedience – a form of protest where laws or the instructions of authorities are deliberately disobeyed – to draw attention to social issues. CoCo has been arrested several times because of her protests.

[…]

Violet CoCo: … part of what drives me is the very feeling of insecurity, of worrying about my own and others' safety … My focus is on the climate and ecological emergency: the most daunting problems that confront our society, our biosphere, and our planet. We now face an existential threat. The sixth mass extinction is underway, and threatens to extinguish 98% of life on earth. Human behaviour is responsible for this.

The Philosophy Club: Could you tell our readers about your projects and your community?

Violet CoCo: I'm an activist in Extinction Rebellion, a global movement of mass civil resistance to the systems of government and industry that are currently putting the habitability of our planet at risk.

[…]

… I came to the conclusion that my highest duty … was to contribute to the greater good. This gave me the freedom to choose to focus on working with Extinction Rebellion, rather than pursuing more individualistic goals.

[…]

… As [British natural history broadcaster] Sir David Attenborough says, 'We cannot be radical enough' … I'm persuaded by both moral and practical arguments that we now have an obligation to engage in nonviolent civil disobedience. This means creating a deliberate disruption to daily life in order to highlight hidden injustices …

Photographer Julian Meehan (© Julian Meehan; reproduced with permission)

Violet CoCo (centre) engaging in nonviolent civil disobedience by blocking a road in central Melbourne.

Source: Michelle Sowey, 'The philosopher activist: An interview with Violet CoCo' (2021, April 3), The Philosophy Club, <https://thephilosophyclub.com.au/2021/04/03/philosopher-activist/>; reproduced with permission

Do not write in this area.

a. Does the good life require taking a strong stance on moral issues? Using CoCo as your central example, provide your own justified response to this question.

Do not write in this area.

Question 3 continues on the next page.

b. Compare how **two** thinkers studied in Unit 3 might respond to CoCo's claim that it is morally required to engage in nonviolent civil disobedience. Justify your response.

Do not write in this area.

c. Which of the two responses that you compared in **part b** provides the more compelling view? Justify your response.

Do not write in this area.

Question 4 (10 marks)

> The harm which is done by credulity in a man is not confined to the fostering of a credulous character in others, and consequent support of false beliefs. Habitual want of care about what I believe leads to habitual want of care in others about the truth of what is told to me. Men speak the truth to one another when each reveres the truth in his own mind and in the other's mind; but how shall my friend revere the truth in my mind when I myself am careless about it, when I believe thing[s] because I want to believe them, and because they are comforting and pleasant? Will he not learn to cry, "Peace," to me, when there is no peace? By such a course I shall surround myself with a thick atmosphere of falsehood and fraud, and in that I must live. It may matter little to me, in my cloud-castle of sweet illusions and darling lies; but it matters much to Man that I have made my neighbours ready to deceive. The credulous man is father to the liar and the cheat; he lives in the bosom of this his family, and it is no marvel if he should become even as they are. So closely are our duties knit together, that whoso shall keep the whole law, and yet offend in one point, he is guilty of all.

Source: WK Clifford, 'The Ethics of Belief', *The Contemporary Review*, vol. 29, Dec 1876–May 1877, p. 289

a. Based on the passage above, why does Clifford think we have a serious responsibility, both to ourselves and to others, to form true beliefs?

Do not write in this area.

b. Compare Clifford's view about the responsibilities we have to society and ourselves when forming beliefs with the view expressed by **one** other thinker studied in Unit 4.

c. Clifford believes it is dangerous to hold false beliefs, even if they are 'comforting and pleasant'.

To what extent do you agree? Justify your response.

End of Section A

Do not write in this area.

Section B

Instructions

- Write an essay in response to **one** of the following questions in the space provided on pages 13–18.
- Write your response in English.
- The question in Section B is worth 20 marks, to be assessed holistically according to the assessment criteria set out on page 21.

Question 1 (20 marks)

Do controversial opinions cause more harm than good in society?

Discuss this question using viewpoints and arguments from **two** thinkers studied in Unit 4, using a case study you have studied this year as your central example.

OR

Question 2 (20 marks)

'We have to be able to trust that we can believe other people and that they will believe us.'

Discuss this statement using viewpoints and arguments from **two** thinkers studied in Unit 4, using a case study you have studied this year as your central example.

OR

Question 3 (20 marks)

'I cannot believe something I have not had the opportunity to experience directly.'

Discuss this statement using viewpoints and arguments from **two** thinkers studied in Unit 4, using a case study you have studied this year as your central example.

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Select a question by placing a tick (✓) in **one** of the boxes below:

Question 1 ☐ Question 2 ☐ Question 3 ☐

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Do not write in this area.

Do not write in this area.

Do not write in this area.

Do not write in this area.

End of examination questions

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Extra space for responses

Clearly **number** all responses in this space.

Do not write in this area.

If you use any additional Question and Answer Books to complete your responses, write your **student number** on the front cover. At the end of the examination, place the additional Question and Answer Books inside the front cover of the first Question and Answer Book.

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Assessment criteria

Section A

Each of the four 10-mark questions in Section A will be assessed against the following criteria:

- understanding of philosophical concepts, arguments, viewpoints and/or perspectives, as expressed within the extract / set texts and as relevant to the demands of the question
- understanding of connections, similarities and differences between arguments, viewpoints or perspectives, as expressed within the extract / set texts and as relevant to the demands of the question
- evaluation and/or critical comparison of relevant arguments, viewpoints or perspectives, and/or the formulation of a justified philosophical position that addresses the demands of the question
- plausibility, coherence and development of a reasoned and supported response that addresses the specific demands of the question
- use of clear and precise language appropriate to philosophy

Section B

The 20-mark essay response in Section B will be assessed against the following criteria:

- knowledge and understanding of philosophical concepts, viewpoints, arguments and perspectives, as expressed in the set texts and relevant to the topic
- evaluation and critical comparison of arguments, viewpoints or perspectives as relevant, and formulation of a justified philosophical position in response to the topic
- knowledge and use of a relevant case study
- plausibility, coherence and development of a reasoned and supported discussion that addresses the specific demands of the topic and integrates relevant material
- use of clear and precise language appropriate to philosophy

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